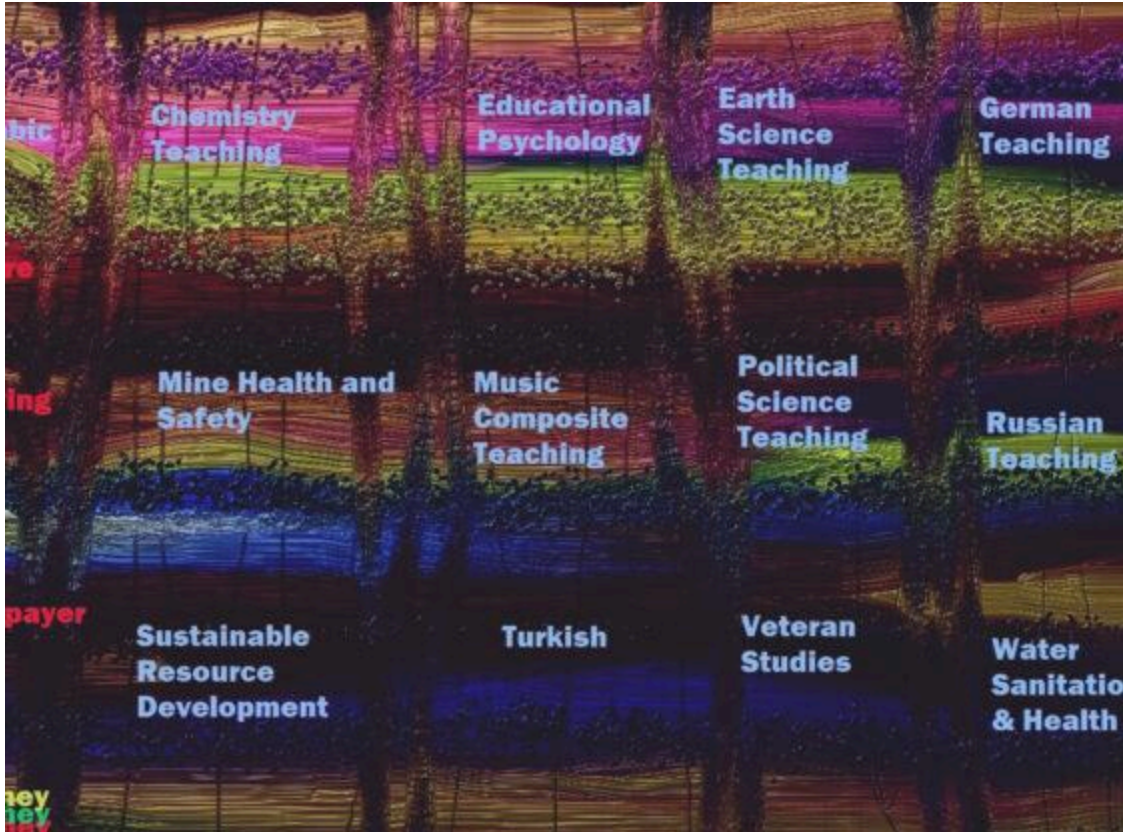




“Rage Painting” by Debjani Chakravarty

Digital painting, 2025

Themes: Rage, affect, feminist anger, neoliberal austerity, political refusal, affective critique

Description

The background of this digital image has been covered in horizontal swaths of different colors – orange, pink, neon yellow, dark red, blue – that have the appearance and texture of metallic oil paint, with finger-like streaks running vertically down the canvas. Text typed in red down the left side reads, We’re saving taxpayer money. The names of some eliminated departments are written in light blue across the canvas: Arabic, Chemistry Teaching, Educational Psychology, Earth Science Teaching, German Teaching, Mine Health and Safety, Music Composite Teaching, Political Science Teaching, Russian Teaching, Sustainable Resource Development, Turkish, Veteran Studies, and Water Sanitation and Health.

Artist Statement

Universities in my state have cut numerous academic programs (at this point, my own university has cut 81, according to *The Salt Lake Tribune*) in response to the state legislature’s mandate to cut higher education budget. The cuts span humanities, social sciences, STEM, critical professional/human services, and healthcare programs. The state mandate follows something

called *Mandate for Leadership: The Conservative Promise*, known widely as Project 2025. The following are some randomly selected quotes from said mandate, with page numbers:

'As Washington begins to downsize its intervention in education, existing funding should be sent to states as grants over which they have full control, enabling states to put federal funding toward any lawful education purpose under state law' (322).

'Congress should cap the indirect cost rate paid to universities so that it does not exceed the lowest rate a university accepts from a private organization to fund research efforts. This market-based reform would help reduce federal taxpayer subsidization of leftist agendas' (355).

'The American labor market continues to experience a glut of college degrees. The country produces more college graduates than suitable jobs for them to fill. Meanwhile, employers exacerbate the problem, fueling demand for college by needlessly requiring degrees for many jobs' (596).

This is a rage painting created digitally that re/presents a few cut programs, randomly picked from a long list, along with an explanation (among others) that we have been given. This work represents my views and sentiments as a private citizen and taxpayer, and I DO NOT REPRESENT MY EMPLOYER UNIVERSITY.